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One of the never-failing ^{forms} ~~sounds~~ of fiction is the witness stand. Some truth speaks, ~~and~~ and in a "fair" trial that truth presumably reaches the judges and jury in parts vivid enough to be put together. Still, this truth is almost never calmly offered nor accepted; it is the kind of truth that "will out." ~~And~~ its principal criterion is not in its own veracity, but in its contrast to fiction. The Oath itself is a sort of idealistic duress; for the main ^{result} ~~purpose~~ of having a witness governed under oath is to get at some truth, but not "the whole truth." ~~And what~~ ^{he} witness can tell "nothing but the Truth" about a particular issue when the very procedure of trial surrounds it with collateral, sometimes deeper, meanings. Witnesses do not take the stand to assist an inquiry; even witnesses who are not accused are, ^{in some degree} on trial. ~~in degrees which might be concretely definable off the record, the~~
^{The} nature of witness-box testimony is not inquiry, but inquisition, inquest, quarrel, argument, and the black-and-white struggle of opposing sides.

TP Thus does the Law use a fiction-form in the hope of getting at facts. A witness may succeed in speaking ~~for or against a witness~~ generally as he planned, but the role itself always changes at least a little the character of his testimony. In the drugstore, at home, judge's chamber, he might speak without his surroundings having a marked effect on his